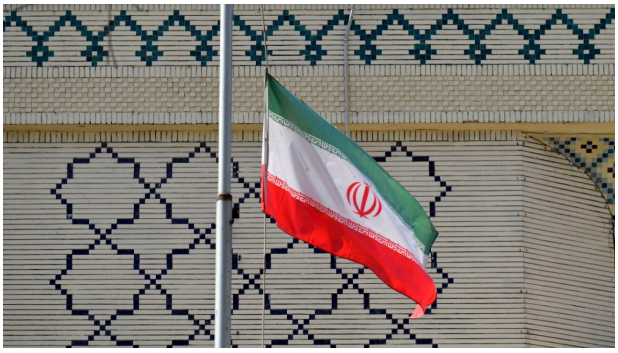
The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Hindustan Times via Getty Images

Donald Trump said he should help choose **Iran's** new supreme leader. The president said that the current front-runner **Mojtaba Khamenei**, the son of the late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, would be "unacceptable". Mr Trump also ruled out a ground invasion of Iran, calling it a "waste of time". Earlier America's House of Representatives rejected a resolution requiring Mr Trump to get **congressional authorisation** to engage in military operations in Iran.

Israel began "a broad-scale wave of strikes" on Tehran, the capital of Iran. It also continued to bomb the south of Beirut, the capital of Lebanon, targeting Hizbullah, a militia backed by Iran. Meanwhile, Kuwait, Qatar and Saudi Arabia reported that drones or missiles had breached their airspace on Friday. The Azerbaijani defence ministry blamed Iran for drone attacks on its territory on Thursday. It is weighing retaliatory action.

Scott Bessent, **America's** treasury secretary, said that his country would issue a 30-day sanctions waiver for Russian oil on ships already bound to **India**. Last month India had committed to stop buying Russian crude as part of a trade deal with America. Mr

Bessent said the “stop-gap measure” would keep oil flowing in the global market during the Iran conflict.

Mr Trump sacked **Kristi Noem** as head of the **Department of Homeland Security**. The president said he would nominate **Markwayne Mullin**, a senator from Oklahoma, to replace her. This week a congressional committee grilled Ms Noem about the Trump administration’s deportation agenda**,** in particular the killing of two American citizens by federal agents in Minnesota. Mr Trump was reportedly unhappy with her testimony.

Anthropic will contest in court America’s decision to label it a supply-chain risk. The government imposed that sanction because Anthropic refused to weaken limits on how the Pentagon can use Claude, its AI model. In an interview with *The Economist* Dario Amodei, the company’s boss, said that the designation—usually reserved for foreign adversaries—would affect Anthropic customers only in their defence-related work.

America’s commerce department has reportedly suggested that foreign companies may be required to seek the American government’s permission to buy **AI chips** made by Nvidia and AMD. In the case of large orders, the purchaser’s home country would have to make a sizeable investment in America, according to the draft rule. Shares in the two American chipmakers fell in response to the news, then recovered.

America and **Venezuela** agreed to re-establish diplomatic relations, according to America’s State Department. In 2019 Nicolás Maduro, Venezuela’s dictator, broke ties because the first Trump administration supported Juan Guaidó, an opposition politician who the country’s parliament appointed “interim president” after Mr Maduro rigged a presidential election the year before. Since America deposed Mr Maduro in January the relationship between the two countries has improved.

Figure of the day: 81%, the proportion of students who failed the 50-yard swim test at Williams College between 2013 and 2019 who were students of colour. Read our story about a tradition that has become awkward for America's universities.

Photograph: AP

The Gulf mulls retaliation against Iran

Iranian aerial attacks are rocking the Gulf. Iran has fired more than 1,000 drones and 196 ballistic missiles at the United Arab Emirates; it has also targeted energy infrastructure in Saudi Arabia and Qatar. Even Oman, which days ago was acting as mediator in last-ditch talks between America and Iran, has been hit. Dubai's airport, one of the world's busiest, is closed, save for a handful of repatriation flights. Thousands of travellers are stranded.

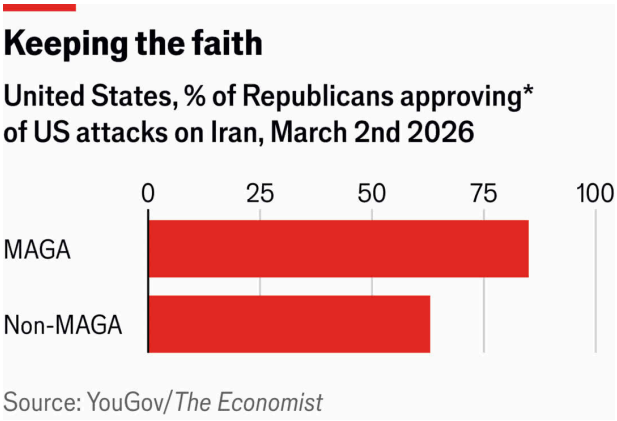
Gulf states are chewing over their response. Anwar Gargash, a senior Emirati official, said military retaliation is "definitely" on the table; Saudi officials suggest the same. That could range from flying joint patrols over the Persian Gulf to launching symbolic strikes on Iran. But joining the war would risk prompting further attacks. The Gulf countries have to consider how long their supplies of missile interceptors can hold out (officials insist they are ample) and how much economic pain they can tolerate.

Photograph: Getty Images

MAGA's split over Donald Trump's war

Donald Trump's war on Iran is roiling MAGA media. Some of the president's most ardent cheerleaders have criticised the strikes against Iran as a betrayal of his pledge to end America's "forever wars" and to focus on domestic policy. Tucker Carlson and Megyn Kelley, conservative talk-show hosts, have suggested that Israel forced Mr Trump's decision to go to war, which he denies.

The president also dismisses the notion that such MAGA influencers speak for his political movement. "MAGA is Trump," as he recently put it. He's probably right. Roughly 85% of Americans who identify as "MAGA Republicans" approve of the strikes on Iran, according to a YouGov/*The Economist* poll. Some 63% of non-MAGA Republicans felt the same. For now, at least, the base is still following its leader.



Photograph: Getty Images

America’s economy turns a corner

Whisper it, but America’s economy might be on an upswing. Economists spent the first half of 2025 fretting about the damage that Donald Trump’s tariff crusade would do, and the second half nervously eyeing the unemployment rate as it crept higher. But the jobs market seems to be stabilising and growth—buoyed by fiscal stimulus from Mr Trump’s tax giveaways—is picking up. The closely watched service-sector purchasing managers’ index gave its strongest reading since 2022 in figures for February.

New employment figures, released on Friday, will help to lay out exactly how much champagne-popping is in order. The previous set was notably stronger than expected: unemployment fell to 4.3% and 130,000 new jobs were created, better than any month in 2025 (many of the openings were in health care). For the moment, the Federal Reserve doesn’t look keen on cutting interest rates again. Fears that Mr Trump’s war on Iran could push up inflation will probably only make the bank more cautious.

Photograph: AP

The hitch in Canada’s global trade plan

Mark Carney is set to meet Japan’s prime minister, Takaichi Sanae, in Tokyo on Friday. It is the first bilateral visit by a Canadian prime minister in a decade, and follows stops in India and Australia. The aim of Mr Carney’s global tour is to diversify Canada’s trade away from America as President Donald Trump muses about walking away from a free-trade pact between the two countries and Mexico.

Yet Canada’s task is not easy. Japanese business leaders will probably stress the importance of Canada’s link to the American market in their meetings with Mr Carney. The country’s ambassador to Canada recently said that Japanese carmakers would need continued access to America to make new Canadian investments. Those firms made 77% of the 1.2m vehicles built in Canada last year. Mr Trump is applying pressure on the industry, too. He wants American carmakers to leave Canada and set up production lines at home.

Photograph: Warner Bros/LMK

The resurrection of the monster flick

Last year "Frankenstein" was brought back from the dead. Guillermo del Toro's distinctive retelling in film starred a gorgeous monster for the Instagram age. Now "The Bride!", a gothic romance released in cinemas on Friday, repeats the concept. Maggie Gyllenhaal's remake of "Bride of Frankenstein" (1935) imagines that a woman killed by gangsters in Chicago in the 1930s is reanimated to marry Mary Shelley's lonely monster.

The cast is frightfully good—Jessie Buckley is the bride and Christian Bale the monster. But the film is frightfully bad. The story mixes too many genres, from a science-fiction framing to a detective subplot. Bonnie-and-Clyde-style capers spark a women's protest movement. (Shelley also reappears, depicted, unfairly, as a spiteful ghost.) "The Bride!" itself never fully comes to life. Still, that won't stop Hollywood from bringing back more famous creatures: "The Mummy", "The Yeti" and "Clayface" are all to come this year.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: What musical term refers to both an individual song on an album and an isolated channel from a single instrument that is mixed with others to make a recording?

Thursday: What type of footwear, which raised the user's height, was very popular in the 1970s?

Perhaps one has to be very old before one learns how to be amused rather than shocked.

Pearl Buck